

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

OPERATIONS

GEMBA: MANAGEMENT WHERE THE WORK HAPPENS

Ohno's circle on the floor, what staff notice of leaders' walks, Womack's purpose, process and people, a randomised study of walking around, Mann's four questions, and a card for your own walk.



49%

of the staff surveyed in 44 neonatal intensive care units were not sure whether leadership walkrounds took place at all.

SEXTON ET AL., 2014

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NO. 40 · OPERATIONS

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A report says what happened. It rarely says how. This issue is about going to the place where the work is done, the gemba, and about what a manager looks for there, asks there, and does afterwards.

Taiichi Ohno made his students stand in a circle on the shop floor and watch. Jim Womack turned the habit into a walk along a whole value stream, with three questions. In 44 neonatal units, almost half the staff were not sure whether their leaders walked at all. In a randomised study in US hospitals, walking around on average made things worse, unless the problems it found were solved. David Mann's four questions show what to ask on the way.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure

Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading

Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice

The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Stand in the circle

According to Teruyuki Minoura, one of his students who later headed Toyota's manufacturing in North America, Taiichi Ohno would take his students to a problem area and draw a circle on the floor, where they were to observe, think and analyse.

“He wanted us to watch and ask 'why' over and over again.”

01

Gemba

“actual place”: where value is created, a shop floor, a ward, a kitchen, a loading ramp

02

Genchi genbutsu

real place, real thing: go and see the facts for yourself

03

Gemba walk

grasping the situation by watching and asking, before taking action

OUR READING

The circle is not about standing still. It is about looking long enough to stop seeing what you expected to see.

Sources: John Teresko, IndustryWeek, 2004; Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014

The circle is known from the accounts of Ohno's students; how long they stood in it varies from one telling to another, so we give no figure. The three terms follow the Lean Enterprise Institute's lexicon.

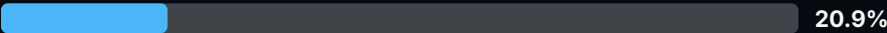
THE NUMBERS

Who notices the walk

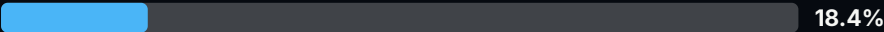
In leadership walkrounds, senior leaders visit frontline staff to talk about safety. J. Bryan Sexton and colleagues asked staff in 44 US neonatal intensive care units about them; 2,073 of 3,294 answered (62.9%).

STAFF IN 44 NEONATAL INTENSIVE CARE UNITS, 2014

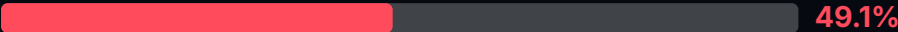
Took part in a walkround



Heard back about risks it reduced



Not sure walkrounds took place



Units where more staff heard back about what the walkrounds had changed rated their safety culture better and tended to report less burnout. In the adult clinical areas used for comparison, 27.6% had taken part.

OUR READING

A walk the team never hears about again is, for the team, a walk that did not happen.

Source: J. Bryan Sexton et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2014

Participation and feedback are averages of the units; 49.1% is the share of all who answered. A survey at one point in time: it shows an association, not a cause.

THE MODEL

Purpose, process, people

Jim Womack, founder of the Lean Enterprise Institute, collected a decade of his walks in Gemba Walks (2011). Value flows across a company, he argues, while the company is organised in vertical departments. So walk one value stream from end to end, together with everyone who touches it.

01**Purpose**

What problem does this process solve for the customer?

02**Process**

How does it actually work, step by step?

03**People**

Are they engaged in creating, sustaining and improving it?

In the foreword to the book, John Shook recalls how Toyota's chairman Fujio Cho summed up what lean leaders do: go see, ask why, show respect. Womack himself told an audience in 2011 that value is always created at the bottom.

OUR READING

Walking alone shows you a department. Walking together shows the handovers between departments, where problems usually wait.

Sources: James P. Womack, Lean Enterprise Institute, 2011 (via Lean Enterprise Institute, press release and excerpt); Jill Jusko, IndustryWeek, 2011; Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014

The three questions follow the Lean Enterprise Institute's lexicon; Cho's words are quoted by Shook. The reading is the editors'.

[More in the essay](#)[KPIs do not improve in Excel](#)

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

When walking makes it worse

Anita Tucker and Sara Singer tested management by walking around in US hospitals chosen at random. For 18 months, senior managers observed frontline work, asked for ideas and worked with staff on the problems. 56 work areas took part; 138 in control hospitals did not.

PROBLEMS PER WORK AREA, ON AVERAGE



On average the programme lowered the staff's rating of improvement compared with the control areas. It worked better where teams took on problems they could solve within 30 days, and where a senior manager was made responsible for seeing a problem resolved. In some of the areas that fell furthest, the time went into ranking problems, and none were solved.

OUR READING

Being seen on the floor is not the point. A walk pays only when what it finds gets fixed.

Source: Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 (via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013)

Improvement was rated by nurses on a 1–5 scale, before (2004) and after (2006). The counts per work area come from the 2013 working paper; the published article (2015) reports the same design and findings.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Four questions, one count

David Mann, who wrote *Creating a Lean Culture*, treats the gemba walk as a repeatable part of a leader's standard work, not a box-checking exercise. He suggests opening with: "I'm really here as a student, and you all are the teachers." Then four questions:

- 1

What's the process here?
Ask to be shown, not told.
- 2

How can you tell it's working?
A board, a count or a signal you can see from where you stand.
- 3

What do you do when it's not working?
Listen for a way to raise it, not a workaround.
- 4

Is there work going on to improve it?
Ask for the last change and who proposed it.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A MONTH OF WALKS IN A DISPATCH AREA

Walks	8 planned, 7 held
Problems	14 found, 9 closed within 30 days
Feedback	the team was told about 4 of the 9

The gap is in the last line: the fixes happened, but the team hardly heard of them. The numbers are invented.

Sources: Mark Graban, *Lean Blog Podcast* #212, 2014; David Mann, *Productivity Press*, 2005; Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, *Production and Operations Management*, 2015 (via *Harvard Business School, Working Paper* 12-113, 2013); J. Bryan Sexton et al., *BMJ Quality & Safety*, 2014

The questions and the opening line are Mann's, from a 2014 interview; the hints under them and the example are the editors'. Counting what is closed and told back follows Tucker & Singer and Sexton et al.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The gemba walk card

One walk, one process. Write down what you saw, not who did it, and before you leave, set the date when you will come back with an answer.

01

Process and place

which value stream, where it starts and ends

02

Purpose

what problem it solves for the customer

03

What I saw

facts and places, not opinions or names

04

What they do when it fails

in the words of the people who do the work

05

Problems I take with me

which can be solved within 30 days; who owns each one

06

Told back

when and how the team hears what changed

Sources: Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014; Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast #212, 2014; Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 (via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013)

A practice proposed by the editors, after Womack's three questions, Mann's questions and the findings of Tucker & Singer.

Open the tool: 5 Whys

stivencatalyst.com/tools/five-whys/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Step Inside the Circle

John Teresko, IndustryWeek, 2004

<https://www.industryweek.com/leadership/companies-executives/article/21942244/step-inside-the-circle>

Lean Lexicon: gemba; gemba walk

Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014

<https://www.lean.org/lexicon-terms/gemba-walk/>

Exposure to Leadership WalkRounds in neonatal intensive care units is associated with a better patient safety culture and less caregiver burnout

J. Bryan Sexton et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2014

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4167964/>

Gemba Walks

James P. Womack, Lean Enterprise Institute, 2011 · via Lean Enterprise Institute, press release and excerpt

<https://www.lean.org/about-lei/press-releases/lean-management-book-gemba-walks-by-james-womack-challenges-the-prevailing-management-system/>

Taking the Gemba Walk

Jill Jusko, IndustryWeek, 2011

<https://www.industryweek.com/operations/continuous-improvement/article/21961267/taking-the-gemba-walk>

The Effectiveness of Management-By-Walking-Around: A Randomized Field Study

Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 · via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013

<https://doi.org/10.1111/poms.12226>

Creating a Lean Culture: David Mann on Leader Standard Work and Lean Management Systems

Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast #212, 2014

<https://www.leanblog.org/2014/12/podcast-212-david-mann-creating-a-lean-culture-3rd-ed/>

Creating a Lean Culture: Tools to Sustain Lean Conversions

David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html